



APPROACHING KIEV

This painting shows the Il'ya Muromets over Kiev during its remarkable round trip between St. Petersburg and Kiev from June 30–July 11. By the end of July, Russia was mobilizing for a war in which Sikorsky's giant aircraft would be put to work as heavy bombers.



JOURNEY'S END

This photograph shows the Il'ya Muromets landing at Korpisnoi aerodrome, outside St. Petersburg, after completing its epic round trip on July 11, 1914. Two figures can be seen standing on the outdoor observation platform.

from which it emerged only after dropping over 1,000ft (350m). It was with immense relief that Sikorsky eventually brought the aircraft down from the cloud in sight of the golden domes of Kiev, landing to an enthusiastic reception. The return flight to St. Petersburg was less dramatic and the total flying time for the remarkable 1,600-mile (2,600-km) round trip was 26 hours. Among the awards and acclaim showered upon Sikorsky came a personal expression of gratitude from Czar Nicholas II.

stable in the air with one or even two engines shut down. The path was open to the design of viable passenger-transport aircraft and heavy bombers.

Sikorsky's remarkable 1,600-mile (2,600-km) round trip from St. Petersburg to Kiev and back in the Il'ya Muromets (see left) provided a fitting finale to an era in which heavier-than-air flight itself had traveled a vast distance from its tentative origins.

Legacy of the pioneers

Flying machines and the adventurers who flew them had conquered the hearts and imaginations of millions of people. Although those who had experienced what Grahame-White called the "great, curious sense of power" conferred by piloting an airplane still totaled only a few thousand, vast numbers of individuals from all sections of society had been caught up in the romance of flight. It was famously embraced by poets and painters, who adopted the airplane as a symbol of the modernism to which they aspired. Italian poet Gabriele d'Annunzio himself became a pilot after hymning the aviator as "the messenger of a vaster life." But the excitement about aviation stretched far beyond intellectuals. In 1911, a school in provincial England asked its pupils to state their greatest goal in life. One



GIANT BIPLANE

The Sikorsky S-27 Il'ya Muromets Ye had an enclosed glass cockpit, which is clearly visible above. The postage stamp, right, was issued by the Soviet Union in 1976 to honor the ground-breaking flight of the Il'ya Muromets.



seven-year-old, the future novelist Graham Greene, wrote: "To go up in an airplane."

By 1914 this era was drawing to an end. Aeronautics was rapidly becoming an industry, and, a little more slowly, a science. More disturbingly, to those who had hoped aviation might by its nature transcend national frontiers and bring different peoples together, aviation had become a branch of the armaments business and was about to turn into a major instrument of war.

IGOR SIKORSKY

BORN IN KIEV, IGOR SIKORSKY (1889–1972) grew up in a household where intellectual curiosity was encouraged. As a boy he developed an interest in flight through reading the science fiction of French novelist Jules Verne and accounts of Leonardo da Vinci's designs for helicopters. After studying engineering, he failed in his attempts to make a helicopter and turned to more conventional fixed-wing designs. In 1913, he constructed the world's first four-engined airplane to fly. Known as the Grand, it formed the prototype for the Il'ya Muromets, later adapted as a long-range bomber for World War I. In 1918, Sikorsky emigrated to the United States to escape the Bolshevik Revolution. After some years teaching, he founded his own engineering company, producing many successful flying boats. In the 1930s he returned to his original obsession, producing the prototype of the first mass-produced helicopter in 1939 (see pages 282–283).

RUSSIAN PIONEER

Igor Sikorsky stands in front of his S-22 Il'ya Muromets. Sikorsky's tried and tested designs proved that larger multiengine airplanes were viable.

